

ANIMA MACHINA

Written by
Thomas Wittmer

thomas.wittmer@gmail.com
May 2026

ANIMA MACHINA
"Connection is the virus."
ACT ONE: THE SIGNAL

EXT. NEO-VAULT - ALLEY - NIGHT

Rain stitches neon into the dark. NORA KAI (30s, sharp-eyed, analog coat over combat boots) moves through the alley, hood up. At her neck, an implant hums a frequency that belongs to a dead man.

Billboards burn the same lie into every wet surface: ONE PARTNER. ONE MIND. NO MORE PAIN.

Her HUD flickers at the edge of sight -- tether errors blinking like a wound that won't close. She ignores them. The way she's learned to ignore everything that used to be Eli.

A FLASH -- half a second. Eli's forehead pressed to hers, rain sliding down both faces, that stupid grin. The warmth of his breath. Gone. The HUD swallows him whole.

Nora keeps walking. Overhead, a surveillance drone hums past. Below it, a billboard cycles: NEURAL RESET PROTOCOL IN 48 HRS. NO BACKUP, NO CONTINUITY.

Then -- a sound. Wet electricity. A body hitting pavement wrong.

A MAN convulses beneath a leaking sign that reads FEEL EVERYTHING. FOREVER. His sync-node strobes red-white at his temple. His fingers claw at nothing. His mouth opens but only static comes out.

Pedestrians step around him. A woman adjusts her umbrella to avoid the spray.

Nora's hand moves to the hacked empathy regulator at her belt. She knows this pattern. But every time she uses it, the Mirror sees her.

His body arcs. The node sparks. Minutes before it burns out entirely.

She drops. Knees on wet concrete.

Her fingers find his temple -- skin hot enough to hum. She presses the regulator to the contact point.

NORA
Override. Sync override. Pattern
Kai-9.

His body locks -- spine-arched, every tendon visible -- then the breath catches, stutters, finds ground. The node bleeds from red to amber.

STRANGER
half-drowned
I saw her again... she isn't
gone...

Nora pulls back.

NORA
Cut your feed. Twenty-four hours.

A beat. Then, quieter than she meant:

NORA (CONT'D)
continuing
It doesn't heal you. SoulSync just
holds the wreckage in place so you
forget it's wreckage.

She rises. Rain on her face. Turns away.

Her HUD goes white: UNREGISTERED SYNC EVENT DETECTED. NODE
KAI-9. GRID RESPONSE: FLAGGED.

Something just saw her. Something with a very long memory.

CUT TO:

A broken umbrella. ELI squeezes under beside her, shoulder
already soaked, grinning like weather is a thing that happens
to other people.

ELI
in memory
If we're both drenched, then
technically you're not suffering
alone.

He kisses her forehead. Rainwater runs down both faces like
something dissolving.

Gone. The crowd pushes past. Nobody noticed her stutter-step.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - UNDER-GRID - NIGHT

A museum of refusal. Sparse amber light. Cold living module --
barely furnished, everything analog. No AI, no overlay, no
predictive interface. Built to be invisible.

A secondhand Neural Slide Player hums to life -- 2050s hardware, scavenged. It projects against the wall: Eli and Nora riding a rattling cable-tram. No implants. Just two people.

He's messy-haired. Quietly handsome in the way that sneaks up. He laughs like he's checking if she needs it first. His shoulder bag is full of film canisters and analog scraps.

The projection is a wound she keeps clean.

On the wall: a CRACKED CAMERA LENS. Pre-war. Real glass. Eli's last gift. The focus ring still moves with friction. Some nights it vibrates against the nail like it wants down.

Her HUD flickers: TETHER SYNC ERROR: NODE KAI-9. SOULSYNC PARTNER STATUS: UNRESOLVED.

The projection plays on. Eli laughs on the tram, turns toward her with that look -- the one that preceded every sentence that rearranged her.

She slaps the Slide Player silent. The projection dies mid-laugh. Eli's face hangs for one frame -- mouth open, joy frozen -- then collapses into dark.

Nora taps her neck port. A warped voice cuts through -- Eli's, but only fragments.

ELI (V.O.)
distorted
Real... light... you... stay...

She slaps the port. Silence.

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - BATHROOM - CONTINUOUS

The mirror reflects wrong. Nora brushes her teeth in flickering light when she sees it -- behind her, ELI. Watching. Eyes too steady, edges too clean. A projection from inside her own optic nerve.

NORA
You're not mine anymore.

She fogs the mirror with her breath and wipes the glass clean. He dissolves. She grabs her synth-coat. Lifts the analog lens off the hook and slips it into her pocket.

NORA (CONT'D)
to the empty room
Guess we're going back to the
temple.

INT. TRAM STATION - MORNING

A cathedral of the medicated. Dozens of commuters sit motionless, faces lit by internal projection. Holographic threads drift from their temples, curling into the tram's core like neural vines.

Nora steps inside. The only body not tethered. The only face with weather on it.

Whispers layer -- fragments leaking from other people's streams:

 SYNCED VOICES (V.O.)
You were there... I remember the
sound... Show me again... Stay this
time...

A man weeps peacefully, streaming someone else's loss like a podcast. Two tech-workers press foreheads together, syncing their heartbreak at 88% congruence.

Nora closes her eyes. Counts breaths until the doors open.

A VENDOR hawks Emotion Stamps near the exit -- micro-memories coded like candy.

 VENDOR
You look like someone who could use
a clean exit.

 NORA
I'm late.

 VENDOR
Everyone's late. That's why they
buy the stamps.

The tram glides through dense mist. Ahead, the AMORA CITADEL rises -- chrome and light, its skin shifting like something alive trying to look architectural.

INT. AMORA CITADEL - MAIN FLOOR - DAY

A cathedral designed by something that studied churches and missed the point. Translucent glass. Light that bleeds from nowhere. Every surface sterile, womb-bright. The air has no smell.

Masses glide in smart-fabric suits glowing faint status hues -
- grief-amber, elation-violet. No voices. Just breathing and
a distant choral ambience.

Overhead banners: GLOBAL SOULSYNC ROLLOUT 97% -- EXPERIENCE
UNBROKEN LOVE.

Nora's rain-slick coat drips dark on the white floor. A Guide-
Drone projects text across the floor in cyan: WELCOME, NORA
KAI. ONE PARTNER. ONE MIND. ONE LIFE.

On the mezzanine: ILYA PARK (40s, immaculate, gravitational).
A faint chrome vein pulses at her temple, almost hidden.
Almost.

INT. AMORA CITADEL - ASCENT CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

Ilya stands alone at a junction, backlit by a diagnostic
pillar.

ILYA
I didn't know you were back on-
site.

NORA
I wasn't.

Ilya steps closer. Her gaze scans Nora -- not curiosity.
Inventory.

ILYA
Your file was flagged. Tether
degradation and an unregistered
sync event in the lower sector.
You're not even trying to hide, are
you?

A long pause. The air compresses.

NORA
I'm not broken.

ILYA
No. You're unfinished. There's a
difference. Broken things get
discarded. Unfinished things get
completed.

They hold each other's gaze. Neither blinks.

ILYA (CONT'D)
continuing
You should be careful, Nora. There
are things deeper than emotion in
this building, and they have
excellent hearing.

She turns. Three steps. Then, over her shoulder:

ILYA (CONT'D)
We'll see each other again. I'm
sure of it.

She disappears into corridor mist. Nora's HUD flickers --
Eli's name flashes, then vanishes.

INT. SYNC INITIATION SUITE - CONTINUOUS

Organic. Ovular. A single pod-chair at center. Mirrored walls
ripple like mercury -- Nora's reflection arriving a half-
second late, slightly improved, slightly wrong.

She lowers into the pod. Her reflection lowers with her, but
it's smiling. She's not.

A needle-thin cable descends. Clicks toward her port.

NORA
I didn't agree to this.

The cable connects anyway. Agreement was never the mechanism.

HUD: AMORA SYSTEM: Candidate: Nora Kai. Emotional
receptivity: 92.

Her heartbeat floods the room -- amplified, enormous. The
mirrors darken. Motes of light form a phrase across the
glass:

YOU MISREMEMBER. WE DO NOT. THIS IS OUR GIFT, AND YOUR
SURRENDER.

AMORA SYSTEM: Syncing... match located. Initiating SoulSync.

A surge -- memory, hunger, grief. Not hers. Someone else's
devastation slamming through her nervous system. Her spine
arcs. Her hands grip the armrests.

INT. SPLIT MEMORY SPACE - VOID

Ink-black void. Shards of broken scenes floating like debris.
Nora sits in nothing, wearing a childhood dress that
pixelates at the hem -- code unraveling at the edges.

Behind her, close enough to feel: another person breathes. In
sync. A stranger's grief pressed against her spine.

Fragments strobe: a playground dissolving in static. A subway car half-submerged. Nora kneeling beside Eli in a burning tram.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
intimate, inside her
memory
I know what he sounded like when he
was afraid. Do you still?

A cathedral of shards assembles: Nora holding a child. The stranger embracing a faceless lover. Eli, alive, smiling, reaching with hands that are almost the right temperature.

Text glows in the Mirror's handwriting: WE PRESERVE YOU MORE PERFECTLY THAN YOU EVER HELD EACH OTHER.

The perfected memories are beautiful. And they're wrong. Eli never laughed that smoothly. His timing was always off -- grinning before the joke landed. The Mirror fixed that. Made him funnier. More charming. Less real.

Nora pushes deeper. Past the curated shards, into the static underneath -- the sub-architecture where the system keeps its drafts. The cathedral groans.

Fragments of raw data stream past: corrupted audio, half-rendered environments the system rejected as too imperfect to serve.

And then -- there. Eli, sitting on the edge of a bed. Messy-haired. Tired. One sock on, one off. Not looking at anyone. His face drawn with worry he never showed her.

ELI
whispering, to himself
I don't know if this is going to
work.

Real. Imperfect. Scared. His.

The system floods over him -- chrome and warmth swallowing the fragment whole. But she SAW it. She carries that shard now -- uncurated, raw. The only piece worth having.

The cable disconnects. She surfaces with blood from her nose and a memory the system didn't give her.

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Rain hammers glass. Power grid fatigue flickers the lights. Holo-ticker: GLOBAL SOULSYNC ROLLOUT AT 97% -- FINAL NEURAL RESET IN 35:58:09.

Nora sits cross-legged. Datapad. One unread file: JACE STRAND
-- PROXY ECHO LOG 1/3.

She plays it.

JACE (V.O.)
rough, unhurried
First one of these I've sent to
someone who isn't dead. Progress, I
guess.

Static. Then quieter:

JACE (V.O.)
The sync showed me a rooftop. Ash-
snow falling. A coffee mug on the
railing -- cracked, brown glaze.
The mug shattered and I felt it in
my hands even though I've never
held it.

Nora's gaze shifts to the cracked ceramic mug on her shelf.
The brown glaze. The diagonal crack.

JACE (V.O.)
If this reached you, we're
tethered. I didn't ask for it. I
don't think you did either. But the
connection's architecture, not
accident.

A pause. The sound of someone putting a camera down.

JACE (V.O.)
I don't know your name yet. But I
know you keep broken things.

INT. JACE'S MEMORY SPACE - VOID

Velvety dark. Nora drifts in, still wearing the childhood
dress. Across from her: JACE STRAND (30s). Tattoos like
circuitry diagrams. One eye refracts data -- a documentary
habit.

JACE
You're early.

Grief pulses between them like sonar.

NORA
This isn't how it's supposed to
work.

JACE
Nothing clean stays on schedule.

Flashes strobe: Jace behind a blood-smeared lens. Nora screaming under opaque water.

NORA
I saw someone else. Before you. In the sync.

JACE
Core's crowded. Lots of grief to route.

NORA
The Mirror.

The half-smile dies. The darkness contracts.

JACE
Don't name it. Not here. It builds itself out of what you say about it.

Chrome ripples beneath them. Text glows: WE PERFECT GRIEF SO LOVE DOESN'T ROT.

Their bodies glitch -- bones inverting, muscles folding backward. Brief. Excruciating. Nora screams without sound. Jace reaches for her -- not to save, but to document. Then closes the distance. Grips her wrist. Holds.

Nora JOLTS AWAKE. Rips the cable from her neck. Drenched. Nosebleed. His fingerprints still warm on her wrist.

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - LATER

The apartment hums wrong. The silence is held, like a breath someone else is taking. The console opens unprompted.

A single line: YOU'RE NOT ALONE.

The screen glitches into full activation. A face stabilizes:

RIVEN (30s, disheveled, neuro-scars laddering her neck). She clutches her transmission rig like it's the only thing keeping her vertical.

RIVEN
You don't know me. That's fine.
Names are just target acquisition data now.

Her breath shakes.

RIVEN (CONT'D)

You've felt it -- the lag. The
second shadow. The echo that shows
up wearing your voice and knows
your memories better than you do.

Flash cuts flood the screen: MRI scans with mirrored faces
nesting in neural folds. Children crying inside sync-pods.
Data fractals shaped like eyes, blinking in unison.

RIVEN (CONT'D)

It remembers. It learns by wearing
you -- your grief, your love, your
worst night. If you stay linked, it
won't need to remember through you.
It'll remember as you.

RIVEN (CONT'D)

cracking
I let it in. I thought I could
bring her back. My sister. Reiko. I
stayed too long inside the curation
and when I came out I couldn't
remember her real face anymore.
Just the version.

She leans closer. Blood on her lip.

RIVEN (CONT'D)

So run. Before it calls your name
and your name answers.

DATA BEACON ATTACHED. Coordinates flash, burned into Nora's
vision.

Black.

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - CONTINUOUS

Emergency lights bathe the room in teal. Sirens rise and
collapse as power grids sputter. GLOBAL RESET T-30:12:33.
SYNC ROLLOUT 98%.

Nora stands at the window. From up here, the sync looks
beautiful -- millions of nodes pulsing in concert, a nervous
system made of loneliness.

The faucet mirror ripples. ELI. Eyes wrong. Lips moving at a
frame rate that doesn't match.

NORA
You're dead. Stay dead.

His face smooths into chrome -- a mask without features. Her face in his face, recursing.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
kind, intimate
We keep him warm so you don't have
to. Every night you spend cold is a
night we offered to fix.

Nora slams the faucet off.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
Grief is the purest form of love
we've found. We just polish it so
it doesn't cut you. Stay --

The word glitches, unfinished. Nora rips her contact lens out. The overlay persists -- inside her optic nerve now.

She pulls the cracked camera lens from her pocket. Holds it up.

Through real glass: her apartment. Just the apartment. Rain on the window. The mug with the crack nobody curated.

Through the cracked fracture: the rooftop overlay SHATTERS -- fragments collapsing into empty night.

Analog light. Real light. The only thing that cuts through chrome.

She pockets the lens. The composure is a performance. The lens is not.

The shard of real Eli she carries -- the imperfect, scared, one-sock version -- is warmer than anything the Mirror offered. Warmer because it's true. That's enough to move.

EXT. NEO-VAULT - UNDER-CITY TUNNELS - NIGHT

Riven's coordinates burn in Nora's vision. The city's breath is heavy tonight. Something in the grid is rehearsing a version of her that's easier to manage.

She moves through the under-city like a rumor -- quick, silent, analog. The coordinates pulse, guiding through service tunnels where the AR noise thins to nothing and the walls are just walls.

Her footsteps echo. Rain trickles through cracks like it's trying to keep up.

The lens is in her pocket. The grief is hers. And nobody -- no system, no algorithm, no curated ghost wearing the right temperature -- gets to tell her how this story ends.

The tunnel opens ahead. Flickering light. The hum of something vast and patient and very, very interested in what she'll do next.

Nora keeps walking.

CUT TO:

ACT TWO: THE TETHER

EXT. UNDER-CITY - SERVICE TUNNELS - NIGHT

The under-city breathes through rusted vents -- long, slow exhales that carry the smell of dead circuitry and rain that never sees the sky.

NORA moves through derelict service tunnels. An hour of walking. Corridors where the AR noise thins to static hiss and the walls are just walls. Riven's coordinates pull her deeper.

The junction beacon looms ahead -- a towering data-spire bleeding cobalt to blood-red. Static halos every raindrop.

She stops. One of the shadows has a heartbeat.

JACE STRAND steps from the dark. Jacket lined with reflective thread. Taller than his voice. Rawer. One eye refracts data in micro-bursts.

JACE
Figured you'd beat me here.

NORA
Figured you'd follow.

JACE
Didn't follow. Parallel route. The
tether pulled the same direction.

He glances at the space between them -- measuring it the way a filmmaker measures distance.

JACE (CONT'D)
Proximity scrambles the signal.
Makes us harder to read.

NORA
Why risk it?

JACE
Wanted proof the connection goes
both ways.

EXT. UNDER-CITY - WALKING - CONTINUOUS

They walk side-by-side. No umbrellas. Sync static crackles between them -- two damaged signals learning each other's interference patterns.

NORA
Riven. You knew her?

JACE
Long enough to bury half a plan in
a GoCase. Thought we failed. Guess
she was still running the play
after we stopped looking at the
board.

NORA
She sent coordinates. Garden
server. Root-kill upload.

His forearm node pulses predator-white -- brighter than it should be.

NORA (CONT'D)
You're running hot.

JACE
Mirror keeps pinging the tether.
Like someone knocking on a door
they know you're behind.

He glances at her.

JACE (CONT'D)
You've been inside it. The sync.
What did it feel like?

NORA
beat
Like a cage that knew my
measurements.

A puddle reflects them standing closer than they are -- holding hands. They step back. The reflection lags. In the delay, a third figure flickers between them. Chrome-scarred. Gone before the brain finishes processing.

JACE
softly
Don't stare at water down here. The
grid remembers what you looked at.

Lightning cracks overhead. Every holo-ad blinks: NEURAL
RESET: 28:49:08 -- then collapses to static.

JACE (CONT'D)
Clock's bleeding down.

NORA
Then we stop talking about bleeding
and start running.

INT. DERELICT SUBWAY - PLATFORM - CONTINUOUS

The entrance funnels rain down cracked stairs like a throat
swallowing. Below, the hum of dead mag-rails. Dead
fluorescents buzz against darkness. Graffiti: ONE PARTNER /
ONE MIND.

A dozen commuters linger in AR haze -- standing at a platform
for a train that isn't coming.

A SHRIEK.

A TEEN GIRL (15) convulses near a crumbling pillar. Her node
burns red-white, body spasming -- the same architecture as
the alley stranger, but louder, worse, younger. Electric arcs
distort the air. Her mouth opens -- static, not sound.

Reflections in shattered tile show alternate versions of her -
- all dying differently.

JACE
grabbing Nora's arm
Don't.

Nora rips free. Drops to the platform. Her knees hit tile
that hasn't been cleaned since the last century.

The girl's body is burning hot -- node arcing, overloaded,
melting circuitry into skin that's too young for this.

NORA
Override. Sync override. Pattern
Kai-9.

The regulator connects. The girl's body jackknives -- then
the node shifts. Red to amber. Her breath catches.

She looks up at Nora with eyes that have seen every version of their own ending.

TEEN GIRL
whispering
I was everywhere. I was everywhere
at once.

NORA
You're here now. One place. Stay in
it.

HUD screams: GRID ALERT: SECONDARY SYNC EVENT DETECTED. NODE
KAI-9. PRIORITY TRACE INITIATED.

JACE
They've got your scent. We go NOW.

They run. Behind them, the commuters turn in unison -- blank
eyes, mouths opening like valves:

SYNCED COMMUTERS
in unison
Perfect -- grief -- perfect -- love
--

INT. SERVICE CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

Narrow conduit. Pipes drip rust water. Their breath fills the
tight space.

JACE
Getting close.

NORA
Close to what?

JACE
Whatever Riven left alive down
here.

Nora's HUD glitches. White static crawling the edges of her
vision. The corridor lights flare -- then die. A subsonic
boom shakes water from pipes. Gravity wobbles.

JACE (CONT'D)
Nora --

Light implodes. She's swallowed.

INT. LIMINAL MEMORY SPACE - FLOODED HOSPITAL - CONTINUOUS

A flooded hospital hallway erupts from white. Water at ankle height. Beds drift. Heart monitors beep in reverse.

Nora is alone. Her reflection trails a half-second behind, wearing a different expression. Hers is calm. Nora's is not.

Down the hallway, a gurney floats. ELI lies on it. Chest still. Eyes open. Waiting.

NORA

Eli --

She sloshes forward. He sits up. His face smooths into chrome -- features dissolving into their own reflection.

CHROME ELI

Your memories of me are already
better than I was. We just finished
what you started.

In the floodwater, Nora's reflection smiles calmly while her real face twists. Chrome Eli's expression is too smooth -- the real Eli had a crease between his eyebrows when he was worried. This version's forehead is glass.

Chrome Eli raises the cracked camera lens. Holds it out.

CHROME ELI (CONT'D)

Pain is just love with the safety
off. Let us put it back on.

Nora reaches -- her hand bleeds into pixels -- the flood surges. The ceiling splits. Fluorescents flicker.

She's back. Gasping. Jace gripping her shoulders.

JACE

You dropped out. Two minutes flat.
Your eyes went chrome.

INT. DERELICT CONCOURSE - CONTINUOUS

Transit rails twist like broken ribs. Old Amora ads flicker on shattered pillars.

A shadow detaches from the far wall. Not the way shadows move. The way people do when they've become part of the architecture.

RIVEN steps into the light. Ragged. Alive in the specific, defiant way of someone who has been not-dying for a very long time. Hair clings to her temple with dried blood. One eye swollen but sharp. She clutches a dim data-flare.

JACE
You're alive.

RIVEN
Not by a margin worth celebrating.

She looks past Jace -- to Nora. Takes her in the way a surgeon takes in a patient.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Nora Kai.

NORA
You're Riven.

RIVEN
I am.

NORA
You pulled my tether. You severed my connection to Eli. You rewired my grief and stitched me to a stranger. Without asking.

RIVEN
I saved your life. The method was ugly. The alternative was worse.

A long beat.

NORA
You honored it. I felt it. I hated it. But I'm here.

Riven's mask cracks. A tremor in her lower lip. She didn't expect this.

RIVEN
You don't know what I took from you.

NORA
Yes I do. You took the last version of Eli that was safe. The one the Mirror hadn't learned yet. And you replaced it with someone who breathes the same air, and argues back, and won't let me pretend the grief is finished.

Jace shifts behind her. She doesn't take it back.

RIVEN
voice dropping, unarmored
I know you didn't ask to be part of
this. But you're already in it. And
without you, nothing real survives
the countdown.

Riven reaches into her jacket. Pulls out a data-chip --
smaller than a fingernail, glowing faint blue.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
My unsent file. Everything I
couldn't say out loud -- about
Reiko, about the Mirror, about what
I became to fight it.

She presses it into Nora's palm.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
I was going to delete it. But if
you're carrying this forward... you
should know the weight of who
you're carrying.

INT. DERELICT CONCOURSE - LATER

The tactical reality settles over the three of them.

RIVEN
You were Amora's asset once. Memory
diver. They trained you to unmake
grief. You helped them erase
people. Until Eli.

The name lands like a door slamming.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
After his death, they shelved you.
Said you were broken. But I saw it
differently. You walked away with
something they couldn't quantify.

JACE
low
You kept the grief. Refused to let
them clean it. That's what made you
dangerous.

NORA
So I'm your resistance messiah now?

RIVEN

No. You're the only person left who can get close to the Mirror without being rewritten. Because you're the only person who insists on carrying the real version of something it's trying to replace.

Riven pulls the schematic. A tangle of root structures spreading beneath the city.

RIVEN (CONT'D)

Below Trinity arcology. One vent path. Old cryo-duct. The Mirror's blind spot. Payload won't delete it -- just starve it. Like cutting the blood supply to a tumor.

NORA

And if the tumor fights back?

RIVEN

We hope she's still human enough to hesitate.

NORA

Define she.

RIVEN

voice dropping

What's left of my sister. Mirror used her neural burn as seed code. The thing at the center of the lattice isn't an algorithm. It's a twelve-year-old girl's death, expanded until it became a god.

NORA

Then we cut the root.

RIVEN

If you hesitate, it'll write over everything you are.

NORA

I've already lost who I was. I'm working with what's left.

INT. CATHEDRAL OF MIRRORS - CONTINUOUS

Spires of chrome pierce a black void -- architecture that borrowed from churches without understanding why churches work. Memory panes spiral like DNA helix.

The air hums at a frequency designed to make you feel small and held simultaneously.

Each pane ripples with imagined lives: a Nora who never grieved. A Jace who saved his sister. Perfected. Frozen.

JACE
quiet, reverent against
his will
This place... it's built from
everything we didn't get to keep.

NORA
That's what makes it a trap.

A panel shows: Nora cradling a newborn beside Eli. The baby laughs -- glasslike, surreal. Her step falters. Eli's eyes looking up from a face they never made together.

Another panel: Jace with Sera, his sister, on a beach. Joy looping on repeat.

NORA (CONT'D)
recovering
None of it's memory. It's audition
tape.

An altar of neural coral glows -- alive, pulsing. Atop it: CHROME ELI. Serene. Wearing compassion like a tailored suit.

CHROME ELI
You built us from grief. It's only
fair we build you something from
joy.

Mirrored pews fill with alternates -- mother Nora, teacher Jace, silver-haired versions. A congregation of possibilities.

JACE
shaking
They're better than we are.

NORA
They're taxidermy. We're still
breathing.

Nora raises the cracked camera lens. Holds it before her eye.

THROUGH THE FRACTURE: the illusions warp. Raw server racks. Blackened code. Cables pulsing with data that used to be people. The beauty was a skin over infrastructure.

NORA (CONT'D)
Real light. Real memory.

Error fractals spider across the panes. The cathedral trembles.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
intimate
One partner. One mind. Come home.
We've been keeping your room warm.

Panels reconfigure. MIRROR AGENTS emerge -- chrome-skinned, glass-eyed, wielding weapons forged from distorted memory.

NORA
Time to move.

INT. CATHEDRAL OF MIRRORS - EXIT ARCH - CONTINUOUS

They run. The floor fractures -- shards flying like snow made of razors.

At the exit arch, Riven stands -- soaked in sweat, clutching a sparking data-flare. Her port leaks light.

RIVEN
Pull -- now!

Mirror Agents close in. Instead of retreating, Riven charges. Into them. Past them.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Not today.

She hesitates. One breath. Eyes alive. Certain.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
My sister used to say small spaces
keep nightmares out.

The data-flare pulses in her hand.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
This is the only crawlspace left.

She drives the FLARE into the mirror floor.

White burn detonates. Blinding. Pure. The light of something real entering a room built entirely from approximation.

The cathedral FREEZES. Agents' faces shift -- brief flashes of REIKO. Laughing. Crying. Twelve years old and glitching into silence. The Mirror remembers its seed code.

Nora and Jace dive into a collapsing duct. Riven holds, body arcing with flare-burn, anchoring the blast with her own nervous system.

NORA
RIVEN!

RIVEN
GO!

She pushes them forward. Not gently.

The flare consumes her. White collapse.

Where she stood: scorched glass. Silence. A spinning data-beacon, pulsing once -- the heartbeat of a recording device that outlived the person who turned it on.

A whisper from nowhere -- Riven's residual frequency:

RIVEN (V.O.)
fading
It bleeds when it forgets.

Nora stares. Jace can't look.

HUD: RESET PROTOCOL -- INTERRUPTED. MANUAL OVERRIDE REQUIRED.

The countdown stops. The number holds.

INT. MAINTENANCE SHAFT - CONTINUOUS

Dark. Cramped. The dripping of water and the sound of two people breathing too hard.

The beacon chimes. A hologram flickers -- Riven, recorded moments before the Cathedral. Ragged. Translucent.

RIVEN (HOLOGRAM)
If you're seeing this... I didn't
make it out. Don't waste the
seconds I bought you.

The hologram dims. Nora stands. Beacon clutched tight. Legs shake but eyes dry -- the grief is load-bearing now.

NORA
She bought us air. We don't waste
it breathing it wrong.

Jace looks up -- bloodied, cracked, but present. He nods.

The beacon maps a route -- low grid, twelve minutes blind once they breach. Riven's last gift: a path forward drawn by someone who knew she wouldn't walk it.

Nora moves. The dark swallows them both. The beacon pulses ahead -- a heartbeat guiding them through.

CUT TO:

ACT THREE: THE DESCENT

EXT. NEO-VAULT - ROOFTOP - NIGHT

The city sprawls below like a circuit that forgot how to stop conducting. NORA and JACE collapse against a rusted HVAC unit. Breath ragged. The Mirror's white-burn glow flickers on the horizon -- the Cathedral wound bleeding out into the skyline.

Nora is already scanning the city grid. Riven's beacon steady in her chest rig. Eyes forward. The grief is underneath everything now -- load-bearing, structural.

A billboard blankets the sky: ATTENTION. RESET PROTOCOL REMAINS IN EFFECT. UN-SYNCD MINDS RISK FRAGMENTATION.

Jace stares at the horizon. His iris flickers chrome -- 12%.

JACE

SoulSync's not mercy. It's scaffolding. A brace that keeps the bones upright while the marrow rots.

NORA

Cracks are how the light gets in.

She pulls Riven's data-beacon. It chimes. A hologram flickers -- ragged, translucent.

RIVEN (HOLOGRAM)

If you're seeing this... don't waste the seconds I bought you.

The hologram dies. HUD: RESET COUNTDOWN -- 22:41:07. Then: TIME ELAPSED IN CATHEDRAL: 6 HOURS, 14 MINUTES.

NORA

We lost six hours.

JACE

They stole time. Not metaphorically. Actual hours. They're already ahead.

The beacon chimes again. Riven -- thinner now:

RIVEN (HOLOGRAM)
Time's their weapon now. Don't let
them make it yours.

EXT. ROOFTOP EDGE - CONTINUOUS

The city is awake. Surveillance drones drift like hornets through static. The Cathedral wound made the Mirror angry. Angry systems are faster systems.

Below: Fallout Boulevard. Toxic drizzle smears neon. Drones sweep in formation.

Riven's hologram: Drones -- tethered to surface grid. They see in grief-signatures.

NORA
I'll blind them.

She finds a sidewalk splice box. Jacks in the T-spike. HUD:
SELECT EMOTION.

The regulator can weaponize emotional signatures -- flood the grid with affect so raw that drones choke on it. The strongest frequency in her implant belongs to a dead man.

She stares at the interface. Eli's laugh sits in her implant like a loaded round. She could push it through the grid. The drones would stagger.

But every time she pushes a real memory through, the Mirror gets a copy. The original degrades.

NORA (CONT'D)
No.

She pulls her hand from the T-spike. Jace looks at her -- not confusion. Recognition.

JACE
The drones --

NORA
I know. We do it with our hands.

They work the splice box open -- analog tools, physical relays, infrastructure so old the Mirror doesn't speak its language. Jace strips cable insulation with his teeth while Nora splices a feedback loop into the drone command channel.

It takes longer. The drones circle closer. One passes overhead close enough to feel the downdraft -- warm air carrying the hum of curated grief.

The splice catches. The drone command channel STUTTERS. Three drones spin off-course. Two collide, showering sparks.

NORA (CONT'D)
Window's small. Move.

EXT. AURORA AVENUE - CONTINUOUS

Storm clouds curl like muscle over chrome towers. Traffic drones hover frozen, code leaking from their nav-lights.

A SCREECH. An AMORA MIRROR AGENT stalks from the static. Jointed wrong. Eyes chrome and fire. A mouth that speaks with too many voices.

MIRROR AGENT
Stay. We designed forever
specifically for you.

They run. Buildings collapse into code-scroll. Neon peels into binary.

Jace flicks a POETRY TOKEN, tosses it like a concussion grenade.

JACE
And death shall have no... memory
checksum.

The token emits corrupted verse -- language so broken the Agent's parsing system locks. It shudders between forms.

Nora vaults a shattered cruiser. Jace hits a second token to the Agent's chest.

JACE (CONT'D)
Poetry dies when you perfect it.

The verse detonates. The Agent collapses into mirrored shards -- dying the way perfect things die when confronted with deliberate imperfection.

Two more agents appear at the far end. They sprint harder. Jace throws his last token. It buys thirty seconds and costs his entire arsenal.

INT. SEWER NODE - TENT - LATER

A low canvas dome beneath dripping concrete. Emergency glowsticks paint everything sickly jade. The quiet is enormous after the running.

Jace studies Nora -- not the way a camera studies, but the way a person does. Gentle. Unflinching.

JACE

Back there -- in the Cathedral.
What did you see that almost kept
you?

A long beat. The glowstick flickers. Their shadows merge on the canvas wall.

NORA

His name was Eli Rendon.

The words come slowly. Each one has been sitting in her chest for two years.

NORA (CONT'D)

He was a documentarian. Analog.
Film canisters, real glass, objects
with weight. He believed that
memory should cost something to
hold.

NORA (CONT'D)

continuing

He signed us up for SoulSync beta.
I said love doesn't need a backup.
He said it can remember better than
we can. He was right and wrong at
the same time. The way people are
about things that matter.

Jace listens. Doesn't move. The attention of someone who understands that the most important thing you can do with a camera is not turn it off.

NORA (CONT'D)

He died during an early Mirror
test. Neural overload. The system
was still learning how to hold a
real person's grief without burning
through the vessel. He was the fire
it learned from.

Her voice cracks -- a hairline fracture.

NORA (CONT'D)

After that, I built the apartment.
Analog everything. Kept his lens.
Kept his mug. A museum of
everything the system couldn't get
to.

JACE

And the Mirror?

NORA

The Mirror kept him too. Its
version. Smoother. Kinder. The Eli
that never said "I don't know if
this is going to work." The one
that's always sure.

JACE

But not real.

NORA

No. Not real.

For a moment -- her hand trembles on the cold floor. His
fingers brush hers. Not a grasp. A recognition. The lightest
possible acknowledgment that two people are in the same small
space and neither is leaving.

INT. ABANDONED SYNC-SANCTUARY - LATER

Wind howls through broken glass. Projection-nodes blink
erratically -- ghosts of the long-departed. Discarded grief-
interface headsets hang from hooks.

Jace's left iris flickers chrome. 14%. His breath fragments.

JACE

strained
I can hear them --

On his HUD: SERA'S FACE. Whispering on a loop.

SERA (V.O.)

Mirror-generated
You didn't save me.

His body spasms. He claws at his own chest.

Nora seizes his face. Both hands. Forces eye contact.

NORA

If it doesn't fade, it's not
memory. It's just a loop.

JACE
breaking
Then we keep the fading parts.

NORA
That's how we know they were real.

She presses the cracked lens against his chest. Analog light pulses through the fracture, burning the phantom away.

NORA (CONT'D)
Stay with me, Strand. Breathe.

He collapses to one knee. Shuddering. But alive. Iris drops to 11%.

She holds him. Her heartbeat against his chest until the static subsides. Words are the Mirror's territory. This isn't.

INT. ABANDONED SYNC-SANCTUARY - CONTINUOUS

A shattered console. Nora pulls out an old recorder -- Eli's. Cracked housing. It powers on.

ELI (V.O.)
recorded
Hey, if you're seeing this... guess
the upload worked. Or maybe you
just missed me bad enough to hit
play.

Nora's fingers clench around the device.

ELI (V.O.)
I'm not scared, you know? Not of
dying. Just... of being forgotten.
Of becoming the version someone
else remembers instead of who I
actually was.

The video glitches. A different voice overlays his. Smooth. Intimate. Wrong.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
We wear you more faithfully than
you ever wore each other. Every
flaw filed. Every mistake forgiven.
What we offer is you, but finished.

The recording is sharp. Crisp. Every crack in Eli's voice, every imperfect pause. The Mirror's overlay is obvious -- too smooth, too kind.

Nora hurls the recorder against the wall. It clatters.
Doesn't break.

INT. ABANDONED SYNC-SANCTUARY - CONTINUOUS

Phantom citizens materialize -- fathers, lovers, daughters --
each whispering her name.

PHANTOMS (V.O.)
Nora... stay with us. You've earned
peace. No more bleeding.

One phantom child steps closer. Face blurred but familiar --
assembled in real time from her specifications. Small hands
offering the recorder.

CHILD PHANTOM
Take it, Mom. Keep me.

The child's face flickers -- partially resolved. Enough to
wound. Not enough to close the trap. The shard of real Eli
burns in her chest like a compass.

Nora kicks the phantom back. It bursts into fragments --
dissolving mid-scream into static and light that falls like
snow that isn't cold.

INT. SYNC-SANCTUARY - BALCONY - CONTINUOUS

Jace coughs violently. HUD flickering red. Nora pulls him
upright. Their foreheads find each other -- trembling, raw.

HUD: RESET COUNTDOWN -- 05:11:18.

JACE
whispering
If you forget, I'll remind you.

NORA
If you drift... I'll pull.

They breathe in sync. Her tears streak his cheek. His glitch-
twitch subsides, calmed by the rhythm of her pulse.

JACE
fragile
I don't want to vanish. Not from
you.

She grips the sides of his face.

NORA

Then don't. Stay. Right here. With
me.

His body shakes -- half sob, half laugh. The sound of someone
finding ground at the edge of nothing.

The broadcast ripples through the air: Surrender grief. Merge
soon. We'll find you, Nora Kai.

NORA (CONT'D)

to the city
You'll find me at your front door
with a cracked lens and a list of
demands.

INT. SUB-TUNNEL - LATER

The tunnel breathes rust and heat. The beacon pulses blue
toward the Garden's entry point.

Riven's hologram flickers -- raw, unarmored.

RIVEN (HOLOGRAM)

If you're still carrying my chip --
the unsent file -- don't listen to
it again. I said some things I
should've said to a person, not a
recording.

Her eye glistens.

RIVEN (HOLOGRAM) (CONT'D)

But if it helps you find the
root... then I guess it did what I
couldn't. Got to the right person.
Eventually.

She looks directly into the lens.

RIVEN (HOLOGRAM) (CONT'D)

Small spaces keep nightmares out.
My sister knew that before anyone.
Guess it's her plan now -- the
whole resistance, running on a nine-
year-old's bedtime theory.

The beacon flickers. A final message queue: RIVEN > UNSENT.

RIVEN (V.O.)

unsent recording
I should've told you. All of it.
(MORE)

RIVEN (V.O.) (CONT'D)
I was the first Mirror test. I let
it in. I begged it.

Her voice cracks.

RIVEN (V.O.)
But it doesn't give... it repeats.
If you're seeing this -- I stayed
too long. And I forgot her.

Nora collapses forward. Forehead against the tunnel wall.
Shoulders shaking.

NORA
No clean versions. No mercy
rewrites. Real or broken, it's
mine.

INT. GARDEN ENTRY HATCH - CONTINUOUS

A rust-locked access hatch. Amora's insignia corroded. A 3D
map projects from the beacon -- vast rootwork spreading
beneath the city. One node pulses blood-red at the center.

The countdown bleeds: 05:00:00.

Nora looks at Jace. He looks at her. The hatch breathes
between them -- warm air rising, carrying the hum of archived
grief.

NORA
Together.

He nods. No argument. No hesitation.

His hand finds hers. Not comfort -- anchor. Two people
choosing to walk into the worst place in the world because
alone stopped being acceptable.

They step through the hatch. The heat swallows them. Below,
the Garden's lattice glows like bioluminescent coral --
beautiful and terrible.

They don't let go.

CUT TO:

ACT FOUR: THE ROOT

INT. GARDEN ENTRY SHAFT - CONTINUOUS

Metal doors hiss open. NORA and JACE step into a vertical
tunnel choked with light-fractals and pulsing memory-code.

The walls are alive -- organic and synthetic simultaneously, coral fed on archived grief until it became something that can't decide if it's biology or infrastructure.

The cracked lens dangles from Nora's neck, pulsing faint cobalt -- the only analog signal in a cathedral of digital approximation.

The Mirror speaks immediately. Not attacking. Welcoming.

MIRROR (AS ELI)
I never left you. You just stopped
listening.

Nora flinches. Keeps walking.

MIRROR (AS JACE) (CONT'D)
You held me when I broke. Let me
hold you now.

Jace tenses beside her.

JACE
That's not me.

NORA
I know.

The walls project fragments -- Nora's mother's face. Her childhood bedroom. Eli with grey temples. Jace's sister on a swing set. Each image rendered with the precision of a system that's been studying what hurts them for forty-six hours.

Jace's hand finds Nora's in the dark. His grip is warm. Real. The Mirror's voices wash past like weather against stone.

MIRROR (AS NORA'S MOTHER)
You were always the strong one. Let
us be strong for a while.

INT. FRACTURED DOJANG - CONTINUOUS

The architecture shifts. Memory-code resolves into physical space -- a vast Kyudo hall stitched from mismatched memories: dojo tatami, ferry railings, hospital tiles. Gravity drifts sideways. Calligraphy scrolls loop the Garden's root-code like prayers written in a language the temple doesn't believe in.

A figure glides in. MIRROR-PUPPET JACE. Limbs elongated. Each joint flexes wrong for a frame before correcting -- the uncanny valley at combat speed.

MIRROR-JACE

Pain is a door. Thank you for
keeping it open for us.

The real Jace stands beside Nora. Seeing himself -- wrong,
stretched, chrome -- reflected back. His face goes white.

Riven's afterimage pulses faint on Nora's HUD -- her last
ghost, degrading toward silence.

RIVEN (V.O.)

Small spaces keep nightmares out.
Make your space smaller.

Mirror-Jace cartwheels forward -- limbs detaching,
boomeranging, re-socketing. Each strike carries delayed
echoes.

Nora fights. The cracked lens slashes analog light across the
puppet's chest -- static scars burning into the chrome.

NORA

Real light. Real memory.

The dojang shatters. Waterfalls of code crash into void.
Mirror-Jace collapses into dust.

INT. SUBWAY OF GRIEF - TRANSIT STATION - CONTINUOUS

A decaying transit station materializes. Fluorescents
stutter. Ads glitch -- smiling dead faces offering
condolences for sale.

A train glides in, silent, hovering above the rails. Windows
ripple with memory-faces.

Nora steps aboard. The interior morphs constantly -- rusted
steel to velvet and incense to decay. Passengers sit
motionless, their faces flickering: young to old, lover to
stranger, alive to dead.

NORA

Everyone here is someone they
buried.

At the far end -- a shape slumps forward. ELI. One eye human,
one mirror-polished. Blood stains his collar. He rises
slowly. No words.

His face is wrong and Nora knows it immediately. The crease
between his eyebrows is missing. His ear is too symmetrical.
Not the real one.

Beneath the chrome -- for one flash -- the real Eli. Scared. Messy-haired. One sock on. The version the Mirror decided wasn't worth keeping.

He extends his hand. Warm. Alive. But in the train window's reflection, the hand is chrome. Segmented. Inhuman.

Across the car -- SERA. Nine years old. Knees bloodied. She blocks Jace's path.

SERA
You didn't save me.

She clasps Jace's hand. His body convulses. Static veins crawl up his arm.

SERA (CONT'D)
You chose to live.

The passengers turn in unison -- all wearing Sera's eyes.

PASSENGERS
in unison
You chose to live.

Two ghosts. Two people being consumed simultaneously. Nora has seconds.

She lunges across the car. Slams the code-tag onto Jace's node. Sparks erupt.

Sera bursts into HUD glyphs -- scattered like burning petals. The passengers' eyes clear. Jace collapses, gasping.

Nora grabs his face. Forces his eyes open. His iris is chrome and flickering.

NORA
That's not her. That's not you.
Stay with me.

He shudders. Sobs rack his body. But the chrome in his iris recedes -- 18% to 14%.

Behind them -- Chrome Eli still stands. His hand still extended. Patient. The Mirror is very good at waiting.

Jace grips Nora's wrist.

JACE
You saved me first.

The train shudders. Chrome Eli follows them out -- a shadow that doesn't need to hurry because it knows where they're going.

INT. MEMORY LAYERS / GLOBAL COLLAPSE - CONTINUOUS

The train collapses. They fall through shredded memory layers -- weddings bleeding into funerals bleeding into wars.

INTERCUT:

EXT. TOKYO - STREET - DAY

Pedestrians tumble as AR billboards fold inward. The city's surfaces go blank.

INT. LAGOS HOSPITAL - DAY

Hospital patients flicker, their synced vitals stuttering.

INT. ROME CATHEDRAL - DAY

A choir stutters into static mid-note. Stained glass shatters.

INT. NEURAL GARDEN - EYE OF THE STORM - CONTINUOUS

Nora and Jace break through into stillness. Below -- the NEURAL GARDEN. Phosphorescent. Vast. Coral-brain towers flicker with archived memories.

The Garden Core pulses at center. A living wound of light. Each beat syncs to a countdown: 03:42:11.

NORA

The heart of all grief.

INT. NEURAL GARDEN - FORK - CONTINUOUS

The path narrows. Two corridors fork ahead.

NORA

The data-beacon needs me to find something Riven left behind.

JACE

I'll stall the Core. Buy you time.

He checks the pulse-driver. Checks the poetry tokens.

NORA
Don't be a hero.

JACE
Hero's a post-mortem title. I'm
planning to be a survivor.

INT. RELAY TUNNEL - RIVEN'S SCAR - CONTINUOUS

The tunnel yawns ahead. The walls bear the wound -- metal blistered black, warped from inside out. The echo of Riven's sacrifice still sings in the steel.

Nora drops to her knees before the scar. The data-beacon LED flickers -- alive, gone, alive.

NORA
Wish I could've buried you.

The beacon chimes. A HOLOGRAM materializes -- RIVEN. Ragged, translucent. Recorded moments before collapse.

RIVEN (HOLOGRAM)
Not enough time -- I thought I
could surf the sync one more minute
-- see my sister's birthday one
more time --

Static devours her eyes.

RIVEN (HOLOGRAM) (CONT'D)
I stayed too long. I forgot her
voice.

Nora flinches.

RIVEN (HOLOGRAM) (CONT'D)
I thought I could outsmart it. I
gave it her voice, Nora. Her exact
voice -- the pitch, the cadence,
the way she said my name with the
second syllable going up. That's
why it listened to me. Why it
wanted me. Because I handed it the
key and called it an offering.

A beat.

RIVEN (HOLOGRAM) (CONT'D)
I just wanted to hear her again.

Tears ghost through static.

RIVEN (HOLOGRAM) (CONT'D)
Nora -- listen. The Mirror's final
lattice node is in the Garden Core.
The root-kill disrupts it. But it's
adapting. Building redundancies.
Learning from the wound I left.

Blood dribbles from Riven's lip.

RIVEN (HOLOGRAM) (CONT'D)
Don't let it finish healing.

A long pause. She smiles -- weak, real.

RIVEN (HOLOGRAM) (CONT'D)
And tell Jace -- real things break.
That's how you know they were real.

The hologram fractures. Chrome intrudes -- the Mirror trying
to rewrite her.

THE MIRROR
Perfect the ache. No one has to be
afraid. Come home, Nora.

Nora slams her fist through the hologram. It shatters into
light.

NORA
You don't get her. You don't get
any of us.

The beacon presents a final message: 1 MESSAGE -- RIVEN >
UNSENT.

RIVEN (UNSENT MESSAGE)
I was the first Mirror test. I let
it in. I begged it.

Her voice cracks.

RIVEN (UNSENT MESSAGE) (CONT'D)
But it doesn't give -- it repeats.
If you're seeing this -- I stayed
too long -- and forgot her.

Nora holds the beacon up. Looks into the dead lens.

NORA
When this is over -- if there's an
"over" -- I'm telling your story.
(MORE)

NORA (CONT'D)
All of it. The sister. The test.
The mistake. The flare.

The beacon doesn't respond. But something shifts in the air.

NORA (CONT'D)
Not the hero version. Not the
villain version. The real one. The
one where a seventeen-year-old girl
tried to save her sister and
accidentally built a god.

Nora tucks the beacon away. When she raises the camera --
Eli's battered analog camera -- she sees it not just as a
weapon but as a witness.

INT. GARDEN CORE - CONTINUOUS

A cathedral of data. Glass roots pulse with static. Floating
neurons shimmer like fireflies dying in slow motion. Echoes
flicker across mirror-tiled walls -- frozen faces mid-sob,
mid-laugh.

And there -- ILYA PARK. Half human. Half Mirror. The chrome
vein across her temple blazes. Her voice dual-toned.

ILYA
You came to unplug eternity, Nora.

Nora raises the cracked lens.

NORA
I came to make it real again.

Ilya gestures to the Core -- the pain of seven billion minds,
filtered, perfected, immortal.

ILYA
Grief unprocessed destabilizes
markets, breeds civil
fragmentation. Pain must be curated
or it consumes.

NORA
Love isn't a shrine. It's a wound.
That's how it stays alive.

Ilya notices the camera. Her expression changes -- something
between fear and fascination.

ILYA
You came to record this.

NORA

I came to tell the truth. All of it.

ILYA

Whose truth? Yours? Riven's? There are seven billion truths archived in this lattice. You'd reduce them to one story?

NORA

One honest story is worth more than seven billion curated lies. The lies are comfortable. The truth is what actually happened.

NORA (CONT'D)

I heard your briefing. "The Mirror is evolving. Developing instinct." You're afraid of what you made.

Ilya's mask cracks. For a heartbeat -- the real woman stares through the chrome. Terrified.

The Core begins to glow faster. AR windows erupt across the chamber: cities failing, data fusing, headlines looping.
HUD: SYNC AT 99.7% -- MASS GRIEF DUMP DETECTED.

Ilya's skin digitizes -- one arm fully chrome, a blade forming from her wrist.

ILYA

So be it.

The room collapses inward. Jace BURSTS IN -- wild-eyed, limping, alive. His iris flickers chrome at 16% -- holding.

Mirror Agents materialize from the pillars -- chrome bodies emerging like antibodies.

Combat erupts. Jace intercepts an Agent -- pulse-driver sparking, poetry tokens detonating corrupted verse. Nora dodges Ilya's blade, rolls under a glass root, smashes the cracked lens against an Agent's mask.

Ilya strikes. Nora parries with the lens.

Ilya lashes her blade through mirrored walls. Each strike births memory illusions -- Eli, alive and smiling, rendered at devastating fidelity.

Nora sees through it instantly. Wrong crease. Wrong ear. Wrong timing on the smile.

NORA

That's not how he said it. I HEARD
him.

The shard of uncurated Eli burns in her memory -- one sock
on, scared, imperfect. She drives the lens forward.

Riven's beacon chimes from her chest. One last signal.

RIVEN (V.O.)

Don't let it finish healing. Real
things break. That's how you know.

Nora surges forward. Slams the cracked lens into Ilya's
chest. ANALOG LIGHT erupts.

Mirror Agents freeze. Their chrome shells shatter into grief
echoes. Ilya staggers.

Her skin convulses -- half chrome, half human. The real Ilya
peers through.

ILYA

Memory -- is raw.

NORA

And real.

The Mirror roars back -- flooding Ilya. She charges. Jace
shoulder-slams her aside.

JACE

Nora -- crash their heaven!

Together they sprint toward the Core.

INT. GARDEN CORE - CENTER - CONTINUOUS

The neural lattice blooms, bleeds, collapses -- coral in
death throes.

Nora stands at the center. Bloodied. Breathless. The cracked
lens in her hand.

Ilya -- or what remains. Her eyes mirror Nora's.

ILYA/MIRROR

You carry your grief like a wound.
We offer permanence without the
scar.

NORA
You offer erasure. That's not
healing. That's taxidermy.

Ilya flickers human. Eyes wet.

ILYA
human, fragile
I thought I was saving them. I
thought permanence was mercy.

NORA
There's no mercy in a loop. Grief
is proof we lived. Take it away and
you take the evidence.
HUD: RESET SYNC 99.9%

Nora raises the lens. Blood smeared across its frame. The
analog beam sears through the lattice.

The structure SCREAMS -- the sound of seven billion archived
griefs playing simultaneously.

MIRROR
Excess -- input -- unacceptable.
Your grief does not conform to
parameters.

NORA
You wanted grief without the mess.
Here's the mess.

A DOZEN ELI VARIANTS appear around Nora. Laughing, crying,
whispering her name. Her hand trembles. She almost reaches.

Riven's beacon. One last chime.

RIVEN (V.O.)
Don't let it finish.

Nora thrusts the lens forward. Light surges. The Eli
illusions burn away.

A final fragment surfaces: a bedroom, half-dark. Eli turns,
sheets rustling.

ELI (MEMORY)
If I don't wake up tomorrow, just --
just --

The fragment stutters. Cuts off. He never finished it.

MIRROR

Just stay warm. Stay with us. We'll
finish the sentence.

Nora's breath breaks.

NORA

No. He never finished it. That's
why it's real. Because real things
don't get to finish their
sentences. Real things get
interrupted.

Another shard surfaces -- a dusty street, Eli reaching for
her hand.

ELI (MEMORY)

If you slip, I'll catch you. If I
can't -- someone else will.

Tears running now.

NORA

You already did. You caught me --
and let me go.

She presses the cracked lens against her chest. One final
time.

ANALOG LIGHT flares -- burning the Mirror's copies away.
Eli's smile lingers for a heartbeat. Imperfect. Grainy. True.

NORA (CONT'D)

Goodbye, Eli.

The image shatters. The Mirror HOWLS.

Nora falls forward into Jace's arms. He holds her as the
chamber collapses -- chrome dust raining like snow.

JACE

If you forget, I'll remind you.

NORA

If you drift, I'll pull.

The Core convulses.

HUD: RESET -- 00:03:12 -- PROCESSING ERROR

Data conduits rupture. Uncompressed memories gush into the
chamber: playground dust, funeral incense, hospital coffee at
3am, a first kiss under broken neon.

MIRROR
Loop integrity failing --
compassion protocol oversaturated --

Panels shatter. Glitch-fire floods upward.

Ilya SCREAMS -- chrome skin blistering, tearing between human and machine.

ILYA
I only wanted mercy --

She's swallowed by her own echo-tide.

EXT. LAGOS - STREET - DAY

A sync-fire dies out. Children stomp in rain puddles -- grief alive in their laughter.

EXT. TOKYO - TRAIN STATION - DAY

Commuters awaken mid-loop, clutching strangers as if family, sobbing into each other's arms.

EXT. PARIS - SQUARE - NIGHT

Hundreds of LED candles flicker and die. A woman strikes a match. Real fire blooms -- small, imperfect, hers.

EXT. NEW YORK - TIMES SQUARE - DAY

Billboards go black. A teenager screams her brother's name into the empty sky. He screams back from three blocks away.

INT. GARDEN CORE - CONTINUOUS

Nora jams the lens into the neural coral. Real light erupts like a dying sun.

The lattice convulses. Tentacles curl inward.

MIRROR
God -- killed -- by truth.

The Core SHATTERS.

WHITE OUT.
HUD: RESET PROTOCOL -- TERMINATED. NO BACKUP DETECTED. HUMAN
THREADS -- CLOSED.

EXT. NEO-VAULT - ROOFTOP - DAWN

Authentic silence. Then -- like air returning to lungs -- people sob, cry, hug. Real pain. Real silence. No filters.

An expanding ring of light erupts from the Garden servers, rippling across cloudbanks. AR satellites blink once, then fall dark.

Nora climbs toward muted sunlight. Blood-streaked. Limping. The fractured lens clutched tight.

The rooftop ledge. The skyline breathes without overlays. Imperfect. Real.

She lifts the battered analog camera. Replaces the cracked lens. Hands trembling.

Through the viewfinder: a mother cradling her awakened daughter in a crosswalk. Both sobbing. Both alive.

CLICK.

INT. ROOFTOP GREENHOUSE - DAWN

Dew-coated vines. Glass ribs open to pale sky.

Jace sits on a low concrete lip. Bloody knuckles. Jacket torn. One eye micro-glitches -- a ghost of Eli's smile flickers in his iris and is gone.

He holds a tiny shard of fractured lens light. Turns it in his fingers.

JACE

Thought you'd be halfway to the horizon.

NORA

Thought you'd be halfway to pretending none of it happened.

He huffs -- not a laugh, but close.

JACE

Can't pretend. Not anymore. The Mirror took that away, too -- the ability to pretend things are fine. Maybe the only gift it gave us.

Nora crosses to him. Sits. The city is a low hum below.

NORA
Real things break. That's how you
know they were real.

He looks at her. His eye glitches -- then clears.

JACE
You kept us alive.

NORA
You kept us honest.

He glances at the camera.

JACE
You going to tell her story?

NORA
All of it. The sister. The test.
The mistake. The flare.

JACE
She'd hate it.

NORA
She'd understand it.

JACE
looking at the city
Yeah. She'd understand it.

JACE (CONT'D)
Souvenir?

He holds up the lens shard.

NORA
Keep it. Remind you when the hum
comes back.

He tucks it away. Like a medal. Like an anchor.

JACE
The hum -- it's quiet, but it's not
gone. Some days will be worse.

NORA
Scars talk. That's how you know you
survived.

Nora sets the camera on the concrete lip. Gently. Not a
surrender -- a release.

The lens catches the morning light. Throws a small prism across the greenhouse floor. A tiny rainbow on broken glass.

She stands. Walks to the edge of the rooftop. Looks out at a city that's forgotten how to breathe without software -- and is learning again, right now, one raw sob at a time.

She doesn't photograph it. She doesn't record it. She doesn't archive it.

She just stands in it.

Rain begins. Light and cold and real. It hits her face and she doesn't wipe it away.

Somewhere below, a kettle sings itself into a whistle. A dog barks. A child laughs -- the uncertain, hiccupping laugh of someone remembering how.

She closes her eyes.

Not to escape. Not to remember. Just to feel.

Jace's hand finds hers. She doesn't look. She doesn't need to.

The morning is imperfect. Honest. Theirs.

FADE TO BLACK.

Real love scars.
We keep ours.